

**Fragmented Traces of Racism in the News:
A Framework for Measuring Large-Scale Patterns**

Abstract

We introduce a framework for measuring traces of racial stereotyping and overt racism as well as anti-racist portrayals in large-scale news corpora. The article starts with a multidimensional definition of racism and discuss the extent to which prior research measures individual dimensions—often in isolation, neglecting their ideational relationship. To fill this gap, a framework for the joint measurement of subdimensions of racism is presented. It captures and combines socio-structural dimensions, core ideological components, group boundaries, and threat and benefit portrayals. We argue that it is possible to apply this multidimensional framework to large text corpora. This allows for comparisons between groups, across corpora of a variety of news outlets within the same period, as well as time series comparisons over different periods. It is discussed how such a birds-eye-view on fragmented expressions of (anti-)racist ideology can enrich existing research and enable us to show ways for reducing racial inequalities.

Keywords: Journalism, Race and Ethnicity, Computational Methods, Racism, Content Analysis

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In his introduction to “Black Reconstruction in America”, W. E. B. Du Bois manages to succinctly summarize what is at stake in racism research: He traces the discriminatory policies of the Reconstruction era and their persistent effects on Black people in the U.S. and argues that if the reader accepts a Black person “is an average and ordinary human being, who under given environment develops like other human beings, then he will read this story and judge it by the facts adduced.” If the reader, on the other hand, regards them “as a distinctly inferior creation, who can never successfully take part in modern civilization and whose emancipation and enfranchisement were gestures against nature, then he will need something more than the sort of facts that I have set down.” (Du Bois, 2017[1935], p. xxv).

There are persistent inequalities of wealth, power and status along racial lines within the modern world. When we observe these inequalities, we either attribute them to the differential situations that racialized groups find themselves in, due to historical facts and persistent social structures that produce these inequalities. This attribution, combined with a liberal belief in equality of opportunity, would lead to the question whether and how society can be changed to alleviate these inequalities (Mills, 2017; Forrester, 2019). Or they are attributed, instead, to an ascribed inferiority of racialized groups themselves, which serves to maintain these inequalities.¹ Racism research is therefore concerned with the questions a) how

¹ There is a third position which could reasonably be held: In the tradition of Hayek (1978, pp. 93-100), one could argue that racial inequalities, like all inequalities in capitalism, do not reflect merit at all—that the poor are often poor for no fault of their own, but that we should accept it and move on. This argument rests on the assumption that any intervention to increase equality will have unforeseen effects that make it unattractive to even try. But as Sen (2000, pp. 255-257) has argued, there is no reason to dogmatically assume this is the case, and instead, it is the task of social sciences to show where there are (or are not) trade-offs between demands of justice (in this case, anti-racism) and other goods (e.g., short term economic efficiency).

the structures that cause racial inequalities emerge and reproduce themselves and b) what leads people to believe the latter, rather than the former.

As communication researchers, we are convinced that our field can contribute to answering these questions, since communication practices are involved in the reproduction of both the described inequalities themselves, and the discourses that justify them. As we will argue in the following sections, we believe that existing research has already covered a lot of ground—either through recent (Kreiss, 2024) as well as established research (Van Dijk, 1991; 2023) that targets race and racism head-on, or in fields that avoid talking about racism explicitly while covering phenomena directly affected by it, as in research on migration reporting (Eberl et al., 2018). We will argue that a present weakness of communication research is covering these dimensions in isolation: We argue that ideologies are a broad spectrum of ideas available to recipients for recombination into (more or less consistent) worldviews (Hall, 2006a, S. 431-433). We argue that just as the empirical research landscape on racism-related message elements in mediated discourse appears to be fragmented, the occurrence of racism itself in said discourse is fragmented. Various message traces that reflect different subdimensions of the multifaceted concept of racism occur at various places of the mediated public sphere. To conceptually integrate these fragmented occurrences, we develop a multidimensional conceptualization for empirically assessing them. This allows for a nuanced framework that is able to capture the occurrence of a spectrum covering “mere” stereotyping as well as overtly racist portrayals, of moderating as well as anti-racist portrayals. We will conclude this paper by demonstrating how such a focus on overall patterns allows for an empirically rich, nuanced assessment of large-scale mediated patterns of group portrayals within news corpora.

In this endeavor, we follow Kathirgamingalingam et al.’s (2025) call to start from a clear and distinct conceptualization of the concept of racism when studying racism-related media content patterns. The following section, therefore, will start with a definition of racism from which our framework will derive. Then we will proceed to give a short overview of how

message elements that can be linked to racism have been assessed in previous empirical communication research, both quantitatively and qualitatively. The final section of this article, follows Kathirgamalingam et al.'s (2025) advice to provide a demarcation to related concepts and include an intersectional perspective. It is discussed how, within the present framework, ideal types of mediated group portrayals ranging from anti-racist to moderating and stereotyping portrayals to overt racism can be distinguished. It is also discussed how measurements of race, class and gender intersect, and how these portrayals can interact to maintain structural racism

What is Racism?

Based on a review of extant conceptual literature², we define racism as (1a) a *persistent societal relationship* that (1b) *privileges* members of dominant groups relative to other racialized groups in their access to material and/or non-material resources. Many members of the dominant group (2) *feel entitled* to these advantages because they see subordinate groups as (3a) *essentially* and (3b) *homogeneously* (3c) *different* and (3d) *inferior* based on real or attributed (4a) *biological* or (4b) *cultural* characteristics. This expresses itself in and is maintained through (5a) *social structures*, (5b) *ideology*, (5c) *psychological processes*, and (5d) *behaviors*. We will argue in the following sections that the degree to which fragmented ideological sediments corresponding to these dimensions are present—or actively opposed—within news discourses allows us to measure the presence of a spectrum of group portrayals, ranging from overtly racist, to stereotyping, to moderating, to anti-racist discourses. Arguably,

² Our definition is based on a review of extant conceptualizations of racism (Essed, 1991; Omi & Winant, 2014; Fredrickson, 2002) and should be read as an attempt to synthesize the various existing approaches. It expands on the definition by Essed (1992, p. 375, as summarized in El-Mafaalani (2021, p. 15). While Essed's definition puts the privileged access to resources of dominant group members at the end of the definition, we put it at the beginning to emphasize that racial stratification is at the core of the phenomenon (Bonilla-Silva & Baiocchi, 2001). Furthermore, we point out three separate elements: the persistence of the relationship (1a) and the privileged access dominant groups enjoy (1b) as well as the feeling of entitlement to these privileges (2)—elements that are present in Essed's writing but not separated within that definition. While Essed defines racism as “an ideology, a structure and a process”, we additionally distinguish between psychological processes and behaviors to allow for a social psychological investigation into how cognitive processes affect individual behaviors.

within democratic societies a wide spectrum of such portrayals should be discursively available—which can then be instrumentalized or criticized by (anti-)racist actors—while the strength of their presence within public arenas is an indicator which views are, at any moment, hegemonic (Hall, 2006a, S. 431-433).

A first feature of racism, as broad strands of the literature conceive it, is that it is a *persistent societal relationship* (1a). By that, we mean it is distinct from episodic intergroup conflict insofar as it produces observable relations of domination over time that possess a degree of institutional inertia (Essed, 1991, p. 39). Policies that alleviate and combat racism are possible (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 137-154 , 265-266), but societies should not rely on the assumption that it fades away without active intervention (Bonilla-Silva & Baiocchi, 2001). This aspect distinguishes our approach from definitions that start from merely interpersonal and psychological phenomena. What results from the latter perspective is that research foremost tries to “separate the ‘good’ versus the ‘bad’ apples in the population through surveys on racial attitudes” (Bonilla-Silva & Baiocchi, 2001, p. 138). This is unproductive insofar as it leads to, on one hand, the pathologization of whoever is identified as an individual racist, and, on the other hand, the (often unconscious) urge of researchers to exculpate their research subjects from this accusation. As we will argue in the following sections, this informs our focus on overall patterns of communication: it often does not make sense to ask whether an individual message is or is not racist, while it does make sense to observe an overall bias within news coverage of a specific group at large.

We view racism as a societal relationship that *privileges* members of the dominant group (1b) as it allows for racial exploitation (Mills, 2017, pp. 118-131) by awarding an inferior status to subordinate groups which makes transactions³ possible that would have been illegal if

³ Mills (2017) intentionally uses the broad term “transactions” in this definition to cover the wide range of interactions affected by racist discrimination: Examples are theft of native land, slavery, laws against interracial marriage, but also targeted violence against racialized groups (which historically could be sanctioned or ignored by the state), higher prices for goods of lower quality within neighborhoods where mainly members of subaltern groups live, exclusion from publicly funded services, etc. (pp. 127-129). What this short list of examples shows

members of the subordinate group would be accepted as equals to the dominant group, or makes the terms of the transactions significantly worse than if they had been treated as equals (p.123). In the sense that members of the dominant group can, knowingly or unknowingly, benefit from these transactions, the dominant group is privileged over subordinate groups (Essed, 1991, p. 43). Mills (2017, p. 123) then distinguishes a “paradigm form” and a “derivative form” of racism as a social relationship.

In the case of its *paradigm form* (Mills, 2017, p. 123), the underlying transactions are instances of de jure discrimination: From Native Americans being cheated out of the land they own, to Black people being owned as slaves, giving inferior access to schooling, housing, and medical care to racialized minorities (pp. 127-129), to the violent expropriation and genocide of racialized groups as practiced by fascist regimes in Europe. In these paradigmatic cases, these inequalities are directly prescribed by law, or at least tolerated (Mills, 2017, p. 123). Once such structural inequalities emerge through institutionalized discrimination, they can remain persistent even after their legal basis has been removed—Mills (2017, p. 125) refers to this as the *derivative form*. The after-effects of colonial exploitation and racial discrimination within countries in education (Bertocchi & Dimico, 2014; Jung, 2023), healthcare (Gomez & Bernet, 2019; Penner et al., 2017), and economic outcomes (Nunn, 2020) are still observable long after despite the de jure independence of former colonies and the de jure abolishment of racial discrimination. Members of dominant racialized groups inherit power positions and can pass on their advantage as generational wealth (Nunn, 2020).

In sum, structural racism can consist of (i) explicit and overt discriminatory laws that maintain unequal status, (ii) informal discriminatory rules and behaviors that affect racial inequality, and (iii) laws and rules that are formally race-neutral but maintain unequal opportunities that were initially caused by (i) or (ii). Without active intervention, these

is that racialized exploitation extends beyond the economic realm and distributes advantages to dominant and disadvantages to subordinate groups in a variety of social systems.

structural inequalities can perpetuate racial exploitation even in the absence of overtly racist laws (Mills, 2017, pp. 122-131).

Advantaged groups can *feel entitled* to the advantages they have inherited from historical de jure racism (2). Historical explanations for inequality—and the normative conclusions that would follow from them (Forrester, 2019; Mills, 2017)—are often ignored in current debates (Siddi, 2020). Members of the dominant groups can feel a “proprietary claim to certain areas of privilege and advantage” (Blumer, 1958, p. 4). Conversely, policies and actions that would remedy those injustices are then perceived as unjust (Essed, 1991, p. 40). Racist prejudice leads to “a fear and suspicion that the subordinate race harbors designs on the prerogatives of the dominant race” (Blumer, 1958, p. 4).

This perceived moral entitlement to privilege is informed by discourses that displace the causes of inequality by attributing inequality to racialized groups themselves, ascribing lower deservingness to them. Subaltern and dominant groups are seen as (3a) *essentially* different, attributes are perceived as innate and irrevocable. This phenomenon has its roots in a widespread cognitive bias: Psychological essentialism denotes the human tendency to understand other people’s attributes as innate qualities instead of malleable characteristics that respond to a person’s environment or a given situation (Neufeld, 2022).

Fredrickson (2002, p. 140) argues that it is this belief in unchanging, innate differences that distinguishes genuine racist ideology from (in his terminology) culturalist forms of prejudice: Cultural prejudice without essentialism demands cultural assimilation, overt racism rules out the possibility of a member of marginalized groups to change their identity—framing conflict as only resolvable through subordination, exclusion, or extermination. But this distinction is a matter of degree: Modern racism grew from earlier culturalist prejudices, and therefore, over time the latter can turn into the former and vice versa (p.141-142), with antisemitism and anti-Muslim racism being prominent examples (Rommelspacher, 2009, S. 26-28). Cultural essentialism can thus play a similar role as biological essentialism (Räthzel, 2002,

S. 6-10). It might therefore be empirically flawed to try to draw a clear distinction between cultural and biological racism (Essed, 1991, pp. 15-16). Instead, we argue it should be considered a spectrum ranging from (non-essentialist) stereotyping to overtly essentialist (biological *or* cultural) racism, with many forms of prejudice oscillating somewhere between those poles.

Essentialism coincides with perceiving a racialized group as (3b) *homogenous* (thus, neglecting individual differences between and heterogeneity of individuals that are considered to be group members) and (3c) *different* from the dominant group—since consistently different treatment is only perceived as justified if the attributes that excuse the behavior are similarly consistently different (Essed, 1991, p. 45).

Furthermore, ascribed *inferior* attributes (3d) are used to justify racial inequality (Blumer, 1958). Racial stratification that serves to maintain a racialized underclass is maintained through stereotypes of *inferior mental or physical capabilities* of subaltern groups. Black scholars have documented the persistent role that myths of racial inferiority played in justifying transatlantic slavery (Du Bois, 2017[1935]; Robinson, 2000 [1983]). After the abolishment of de jure discrimination, persistent inequalities were often first explained as stemming from inequalities in cognitive abilities, later, as these explanations lost credibility, theories attributing cultural inferiority emerged (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 39-41). In European countries, perceptions of immigrants from poor non-white countries as less industrious or capable inform anti-immigrant attitudes (Alesina et al., 2023), welfare chauvinism (Roemer et al., 2007; Careja & Harris, 2022), and attitudes towards punitive state action (Peffley et al., 2017; Ousey & Unnever, 2012). Additionally, racist ideologies often ascribe *inferior moral status and pernicious motives* to racialized groups to justify discrimination. While these two dimensions of negative stereotypes overlap for minority groups that are limited to lower-class status, they diverge in minority groups that attain middle-class status in large numbers: Here, ascribing inferior capabilities appears less credible—instead, racialized minorities are perceived

as highly capable, but holding pernicious motives (Fiske, 2018). For example, Fredrickson (2002, pp. 87-90) documents how antisemitic stereotypes switched from the former to the latter.

In this process, people are grouped into races on the basis of arbitrary markers (4): Through the focus on *biological* (4a) and often phenotypic markers, racism gains what Omi and Winant (2014) refer to as the “visual dimension” of racial formation: Racialized groups are often racialized based on visible and more-or-less unalterable qualities, which makes it hard for victims of racism to escape discrimination (p. 111): Where cultural minorities have the ability to assimilate by adopting the dominant culture, racial minorities do not have the option to “pass” as a member of the dominant group (p. 40-41). At the same time, the arbitrary nature of racial markers allows for the boundaries of group-membership to shift—for example, groups that were perceived as non-white in the 19th century “became white” in the 20th (p.13); within different countries, the boundaries of “whiteness” can be interpreted differently, and within the same society, and within different sub-cultures, group-membership can be strategically renegotiated by both dominant and subaltern groups (p. 124-130, 138).

Cultural attributes (4b), similarly, can be used to group people, constructing different ethnicities as categories both of chosen self-identification, but also as markers of hierarchical difference. Essentialized nationalism was a source for stratification within European societies even before the emergence of modern racism (Robinson, 2000 [1983], pp. 24-28). Today, while biological explanations of racial differences are increasingly taboo, essentialized cultural identities often take their place (Arndt, 2011, S. 44-45; Räthzel, 2002, S. 6-10; Hall, New ethnicities, 2006b) and are often hard to distinguish from biological racism (Essed, 1991, pp. 15-16), particularly since modern racist ideologies use cultural terminology as a chiffre for overtly racist intent (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 191-198; Räthzel, 2002, S. 6-10).⁴

⁴ While the process of racial marking often initially serves to enable racist discrimination, racialized groups often adopt racial identities to organize against racial stratification—just as victims of other forms of discrimination can organize around a shared identity on the basis of being discriminated against. Therefore, antiracist movements that organize around a racial identity to demand equal status for members of their group (e.g. Black Lives Matter) have to be distinguished from racist movements that demand superior status for members of

It follows from the preceding paragraphs that the persistence of racism can be explained through the interplay of structural, ideological, attitudinal, and behavioral components. We use the term racial stratification to suggest that racism historically first emerges as (5a) *structural* inequality of institutionalized unequal treatment, with theories of biological races emerging later to justify this inequality (Bonilla-Silva & Baiocchi, 2001; Fredrickson, 2002, pp. 17-47). Simply put: “Race did not produce inequality; inequality produced race” (Williams, 2019, p. 657).

Racist *ideologies* (5b) then serve to justify persistent racial inequalities and exploitation against the backdrop of dominant liberal values that are nominally incompatible with racism. Dominant groups as well as subaltern groups know the stereotypes that exist, and adjust their behavior, whether or not they agree with them (Essed, 1991, pp. 41-42). As communication scientists, we will treat public communication as one avenue for the communication of differing (anti-)racist ideologies and see news production as one arena to reproduce or challenge widespread beliefs (Van Dijk, 1991; Hall, 2006a). Racial stratification is not just maintained through shared knowledge, but also via shared ignorance: While stereotypes that “explain” the inferiority of subaltern groups are widely shared, alternative explanations for inequalities that explain their injustice are often forgotten or downplayed (Feagin, 2020, pp. 27-28)—until anti-racist movements counter dominant narratives.

This is translated into individual *attitudes* (5c) towards dominant and subaltern groups. Attitudes can range from explicitly racist attitudes that consciously affirm racial inequality, to passive ignorance of racial injustice (with strategic and willful ignorance at the overlap of the two) (Essed, 1991, p. 42), to anti-racist attitudes that confront and aim to alleviate racial inequality.

their group (e.g. white supremacist movements)—the distinguishing feature is not whether they appeal to a racialized group identity, but whether they demand equality or inequality (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 124-130).

Lastly, individual attitudes are translated into *behavior* (5d) that can maintain —or reform—racist structures: “structures and ideologies do not exist outside the everyday practices through which they are created and confirmed” (Essed, 1991, p. 44). While there is a tendency within dominant discourses to focus on the intent of actors when it comes to racism, within social science, the effects of actions are more important both to explain actual outcomes and to achieve structural change (Bonilla-Silva & Baiocchi, 2001, p. 138).

As we will argue within the following sections, while the object of our research will be on the ideological level (with news texts being, among other things, expressions of widely spread beliefs), we think that the underlying framing of news articles can give us an insight into how this ideological content provides the link from structural inequalities to attitudes and suggested behaviors that maintain—or alleviate—underlying structural inequality.

Extant Communication Research Capturing to the Concept of Racism

Going through the dimensions of the preceding section, one finds that communication research often already offers substantial insight into them, explicitly or implicitly. Yet, these existing insights are only seldom explicitly connected to racism as an overarching concept.

For instance, there is research that investigates how *persistent racial stratification* (1) of different groups affects how these groups are portrayed in different social roles in mediated discourse. Shor and Rijt (2024) test the hypothesis if different racialized groups are disproportionately portrayed in prominent roles in Entertainment, Politics, Business, Sports, Crime, Arts and Literature, and Science, using their proportional occurrence in those roles on Wikipedia as a baseline. They find that media portrayals do not systematically diverge, even overrepresenting Black people in some high status positions. While the authors interpret this result as disproving the bias hypothesis, another interpretation is that the studied news discourses *accurately portray* racial stratification in US society: For example, both on Wikipedia and in the news in Shor and Rijt’s data (p. 14), Black people (who make up 12 percent of the population) make up around 2.13 percent of the most prominent scientists. News

coverage does not diverge from *this structural inequality*—it reproduces it. Computational analyses assessing visual representation of racialized minority groups in the media show similar patterns: Ash et al. (2022) and Ibrahim et al. (2024) compare the representation of different groups in images in *New York Times* and *Fox News* web articles, finding stereotypical portrayals that disproportionately portray Black people in sports and underrepresent them in science, politics and technology, while Hispanic people are disproportionately shown in manual labor jobs and Asian people in technology and science. The overrepresentation of racialized groups in crime reporting (e.g. Dixon and Linz, (2000)) varies depending on the political salience of racial biases in reporting (e.g. Dixon and Williams, (2015), Dixon, (2017)).

The portrayal of existing inequalities might be harmless⁵ if it was not tied to discourses on *entitlement* (2). Reporting on poverty disproportionately portrays racialized minorities in positions of poverty, *especially* in contexts where poverty is portrayed as deserved (Gollust et al., 2025; Van Doorn, 2015). Similarly, within news—as within other discursive fields—it is still often contested whether racism should be seen a systemic problem (Robles & Xie, 2024). By attributing blame to individuals rather than broader structures, racist policing can be turned into a discussion about bad individuals rather than systemic causes for racial disparities (Bremner, 2023). Inequities in health outcomes, similarly, can only be overcome if they are, first, addressed as effect of racial inequity (Mahmood et al., 2025). Mejia et al. (2018) connect this topic to the debate on “post-truth” politics: Rather than disinformation being a recent phenomenon, examples such as reporting on drug policing and housing policy show that narratives that blame the results of structurally discriminatory policies on the victims of these policies is a long-standing pattern within American news. As Müller et al. (2025) and Müller et al. (2023) are able to show, whether elite discourses emphasize social exclusion and downplay

⁵ It could even be alleviating inequalities, in cases where it is combined with discourses that discuss how to counter these inequalities, as we will argue in the next sections.

the effects of racist discrimination, or conversely, emphasize cultural diversity and multiculturalism, affects the electorate's perception of discrimination.

The portrayal of groups as homogenized, essentialized, different, and inferior (3) has also received attention in communications research: Reddi et al. (2023) show how “identity propaganda” was strategically mobilized by Donald Trump to call the legitimacy of vice president Kamala Harris into question by relying on existing othering and essentializing narratives as well as questioning the authenticity of her racial background. Soto-Vásquez & Gonzalez (2022) show that reporting on Hispanic voter behavior relies on essentializing and stereotyping narratives even when describing heterogeneous voting behavior. Two extreme cases of othering and essentializing are also often the main focus of racism research within communications: Under the umbrella of Hate Speech, very overt forms of racist speech are often covered, at the same time often lacking solid theoretical grounding, and with an focus on episodic, offending speech which does not allow for broader, structural analyses, as Kathirgamalingam et al. (2025, p. 10) observe. Second, within immigration news, the use of dehumanizing metaphors—floods, masses, hordes—is a commonly investigated theme (for a summary Eberl (2018, p. 214), e.g. Baker et al. (2008))

The presence of narratives of group inferiority has been extensively researched using the Stereotype Content Model (SCM; (Cuddy et al., 2008). Studies have found a stable divergence of outgroup stereotypes along the lines of ascribed competence and assertiveness (combined to the “competence” dimension) on one hand, and sociability and morality on the other (combined to the “warmth” dimension) both on the level of individuals' attitudes (Fiske, 2018) and within mediated public discourse (Durante et al., 2010; Kroon et al., 2021; Nicolas et al., 2021; Fiske, 2018). Results within this tradition already tie those stereotypes to (perceived) social positions of actors, explaining that competence is tied to being perceived to be in positions of wealth and power, while the absence of warmth is explained with resource competition: Groups that are perceived in competition with the dominant group are ascribed

stereotypes of high competence but low warmth. What should be added from the perspective of historical and current racism research is that the level of political organizing of affected groups mediates those structural effects: For example, prejudice against Black workers (Robinson, 2000 [1983], pp. 200-203) and between white ethnic groups (Robinson, 2000 [1983], pp. 208-212) was a factor preventing solidarity across racial lines in the US, but the perceived *competition* between Black and white workers always *depended* on the level of organization of Black movements and shifting alliances between Black labor, white labor, and other organized interests. Kende et al. (2023) observe a similar pattern today: The perception of discrimination within a society does not directly correspond to the degree of discrimination against racial minority groups, but majority group members are more likely to acknowledge the existence of discrimination the more access minority groups have to elite political positions. Stereotypes and narratives of unequal deservingness, therefore, are not directly caused by structural inequality, but also mediated by the ability of minority groups to speak up against them.

A differential portrayal of racialized groups is possible because different group identities based on biological or cultural characteristics (4) are (re)produced within reporting. Deckard et al. (2020), for example, are able to show how a Latinx immigrant identity is shaped through the choice of images and narratives in US immigrant reporting. As Eberl et al. (2018, pp. 209-210) summarize, who is shown as an immigrant, and what labels are used to demarcate groups, shapes immigration reporting in Europe.

Regarding the connection between structure, ideology, individual attitudes, and behavior (5), we will argue that common narrative frames concerning minority groups serve to tie together perceptions of social structure, deservingness, and innate ability with perceived appropriate causes of individual and political action: For example—often without explicitly addressing racism—research on immigration reporting and “anti-immigrant sentiment” offers insights: Within this field, measuring economy, culture and security threat frames has become

a standard tool, with results indicating that these threat frames inform anti-immigrant attitudes and voting behavior within the audience (Eberl et al., 2018). Notably, racism researchers have pointed out that racial stereotypes against domestic minority groups follow the same pattern (Feagin, 2020). And it is observed that the association with different threat frames affects different nationalities to a different degree (Eberl et al., 2018), and that anti-immigrant and welfare chauvinist attitudes are largely influenced by misperceptions of how large different immigrant groups are, and to what degree they contribute to the economy (Alesina et al., 2023).

Taken together, this suggests that economy, culture and security threat (and benefit) frames are seen as discourses associated with different racialized groups to a different degree—with immigration policy being one tool among others to maintain group hierarchies (Kustov, 2019). These broader narrative frames inform attitudes and connect them with policy prescriptions: Economic threat frames suggest restrictive immigration policies and punitive social welfare policies as a remedy (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 270-271). Security threat frames suggest harsher penalization, discriminatory policing, and restriction of immigration (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 116-117, 181-183), despite empirical evidence that immigration, over all, is not consistently related to the overall crime rate (Boateng et al., 2021) and more often with a reduction in crime rather than an increase (Ousey & Unnever, 2012; Adelman et al., 2017). Culture threat frames suggest the need for culturally supremacist policies or outright exclusion (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 241-242). As we will argue below, these frames will be countered by anti-racist frames that offer opposing narratives—the measurement of the current state of discourses regarding different minority groups will rely on the relative strength of opposing narrative frames in connection with different groups. Therefore, we consider threat and benefit frames as the element within the ideological portrayal of groups that ties ideology to attitudes and behaviors.

A Framework for Assessing the Fragmented Occurrence of Racism in Public Discourse

Expanding on the existing literature, we will now sketch a framework for assessing the reproduction of (anti-)racist ideology within journalistic texts. This framework is based on three basic assumptions: (1.) We argue that sediments of racial ideology as they are expressed within public communication can be derived from and will interact with (but not simply mirror) the different sub-dimensions of racism as defined above. (2.) We assume that these elements occur as fragmented patterns within public discourse: There will hardly be any journalistic texts that touch upon all sub-dimension of racism at once. Nonetheless, just like with other political ideologies—for instance populism (see, (Engesser et al., 2020; Engesser et al., 2017)—the individual sub-dimensions will occur in diverse texts, speeches, posts, etc. in a dispersed manner. (3.) Corresponding to (1a), *the persistence of patterns over time*, we assume that if one aggregates the different occurrences of expressions towards different groups within a corpus, it is possible to observe different portrayals according to the ebb and flow of stereotyping and (anti-)racist discourse, allowing us to map the portrayal of different groups. Therefore, a framework for assessing the fragmented occurrence will identify individual dimensions that can be used as indicators by either measuring the relative occurrence of positive versus negative portrayals (e.g., competence versus incompetence in the SCM), or by measuring the share of statements that contain an element over all statements mentioning the group (e.g. by measuring the share of homogenizing statements).

Public communication, we assume, will reflect (1b) *differential access to resources* between group members. We aim to measure, broadly, the share of mentions where group members are portrayed within upper class roles (e.g. politicians, celebrities, athletes, academics, experts, economic elites) and middle class roles (e.g. no attribution of status, civil society representatives, white collar professions), versus in lower class roles (e.g. as “unskilled” laborers, welfare recipients, unemployed, or perpetrators/suspects of a crime). Since on one hand, prominence and elite status of actors is a news factor influencing which news gets

reported on (Eilders, 2006) and, on the other hand, news are focusing on social problems (Boydstun, 2013), our assumption is that both elite groups and deviant groups—criminals and economically marginalized groups—are overrepresented within reporting. Racial stratification will lead to an overrepresentation of marginalized groups within the latter group, and underrepresentation within the former within news reporting, exaggerating statistical differences.

Next, we will measure the degree of (2) moral entitlement to higher status for the dominant group, that is, a *proprietary claim to resources* and *fear of encroachment* (Blumer, 1958, p. 4). Discourses overtly hostile to an outgroup will portray people classified as group members as receiving more than they deserve and measures that aid groups in need will be described as excessive and wasteful (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 191-205). Opposed to this, anti-racist discourses, meanwhile, will point out that marginalized groups suffer from violence, economic exploitation, social exclusion, lack of access to power, and cultural marginalization (Young, 1990, pp. 39-64) and point out the as-of-yet unrealized character of racial equality and democracy (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 146-147; Mills, 2017, pp. 131-135).

Next, we will measure the degree of (3a) *essentialization* by measuring the share of messages containing references to biological markers such as “blood”, “DNA”, or references to a “national character” or “Volksgeist” (Fredrickson, 2002, pp. 70-72) and transferring and expanding psychological measures for essentialism (Roth et al., 2023) to content analysis. Regarding the representation of (3b) *alleged homogeneity of outgroups* in public discourse, we see the use of generics (e.g., “Italians like sports”) (Haslanger, 2010) as an indicator. While the use of generalizing language is not per se discriminatory, and can in individual cases serve anti-racist messaging as well (Saul, 2023), tracing the disparate use of generics over different racialized groups might serve as an indicator for the degree to which generalizing language is used. The (3c) *difference* to the dominant group is often expressed in direct comparisons (“Us” vs. “Them”) (Wodak, 2015, pp. 76-79), or with “model minorities”, whose successes are used

to distinguish deserving from undeserving groups (Poon et al., 2016). Therefore, measuring the occurrence of these comparisons can serve as a content-analytical indicator. The representation of (3d) *alleged outgroup inferiority* will be measured using the Stereotype Content Model, assessing the degree to which different groups are portrayed as competent versus incompetent and warm versus cold (Durante et al., 2010; Kroon et al., 2021; Nicolas et al., 2021; Fiske, 2018).

We will assess how the (4) *boundaries* of racialized group membership are continuously renegotiated (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 124-130, 138) by assessing the degree to which different groups are distinguished along national lines (e.g. “Somali”, “Afghan”), or are associated with racial (“Black”, “Mediterranean looking”) or religious-cultural (“Muslim”, “Arab”) markers. On the corpus level, synonym identification can help us identify which groups are considered similar or part of the same larger group, while cluster analyses of portrayed stereotypes can help identify groups that are portrayed in similar ways in discourse (Durante et al., 2010; Durante et al., 2017).

Finally, the ideology transported within news content is (5) *linking the content of reporting back to social structure as well as to attitudes and behaviors of the audience*. Here, we can expand on previous works from both immigration reporting as well as racism research: Economic threat frames portray groups as costing the larger society more than they contribute (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 270-271), Security threat frames portray racialized outgroups as (implicitly) innately causing crime (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 116-117, 181-183), and Culture threat frames portray the presence of cultural groups as threatening the persistence of the dominant culture (Eberl et al., 2018, pp. 211-213; Feagin, 2020, pp. 241-242),.

Opposing these threat frames, within the immigration literature only “hero” frames—that portray group members as protecting their families or serve society at large—are established to arouse positive sentiment towards marginalized groups (Eberl et al., 2018, p.

214). We argue here that only constructive frames that offer alternate courses of action for improvement can counter the effects of threat frames (Wodak, 2015, pp. 188-189). Marginalized minority groups have a tradition of countering threat frames by highlighting the contribution of racial minorities to societal wealth, particularly their past and present exploitation (Feagin, 2020, pp. 173-174), their independent cultural advances and their contribution to the dominant culture (Feagin, 2020, pp. 198-200), and the role marginalization plays in fostering criminality and the advances marginalized groups themselves make in reducing these effects (Feagin, 2020, pp. 181-183). Constructive frames will point out how economic and cultural integration and justice are beneficial to all, and how integration rather than exclusion serves societal stability.

Taken together, this multi-dimensional framework enables researchers to detect broader patterns of racialized group depictions within larger corpora of communicated messages. If a broader selection of the message features we have outlined in this section could be assessed within one study, and thus, message elements that represent or originate from the various sub-dimensions of racist ideology could be captured simultaneously, a detailed mapping of different types or variants of discourse would become apparent. The goal, then, would not be to classify individual texts as racist or not racist, but rather to give an overview over patterns emerging over the output of one outlet, or a corpus belonging to different public arenas (e.g. regional journalism, nationwide journalism, left-leaning, and right-leaning journalism, etc.) or of the complete public sphere within a country. The framework can also be applied to document changes over time in the depiction of racialized groups within a public sphere, or to compare their depiction across different national settings.

Discussion: Mapping a spectrum of portrayals

Recent advances in computational methods allow for the measurement of the distribution of these dimensions within large-scale corpora (Kathirgamalingam et al., 2025; Guo et al., 2023; Ibrahim et al., 2024). If the portrayal of different groups are aggregated on the

corpus level (for example, of all outlets within a country and a timeframe, or within a group of outlets), different groups will show different cumulative patterns of portrayal. Measuring the broad set of dimensions has two advantages: One, the combination of dimensions allows for a more nuanced overview of the portrayals of different groups within the news. Two, once we have identified established patterns of portrayals, we can test the contribution of individual dimensions to the formation and persistence of (anti-)racist attitudes within the audience through experimental research.

We argue that for every group portrayal observed within a corpus, it can be placed on a spectrum between the following ideal types:

It will be called an *overtly racist portrayal* when the overall portrayal focuses on proprietary claims to resources for the dominant group (as opposed to equal access), when a group is portrayed as essentialized, homogenous, and different from the dominant group and other sympathically portrayed groups, when they are ascribed lower warmth (and, in some cases, lower competence), and when it is overwhelmingly portrayed as threatening. A *Stereotyping portrayal* will be distinguished from this by sharing all the elements of negative portrayal except for not containing essentialization, homogenization and differentiation. We assume that overt racist portrayals are rare within, for example, mainstream reporting, compared to far-right outlets, while stereotyping portrayals will be more common. A *moderating portrayal* of a group is found when close to equal attention to egalitarian claims to access to resources and a proprietary claim to resources by dominant groups is observed—without essentialization, homogenization and differentiation from other groups— but with ascription of competence and warmth equal to the portrayal of sympathetic groups, and an equal proportion of threatening and beneficial frames in combination with the group.⁶

⁶ We consciously label stereotyping and moderating portrayals neither racist nor non-racist. Stereotyping portrayals can contribute to maintaining prejudices that can inform openly racist as well as more covert discrimination and attempts at moderation can have the effect of legitimizing prejudice. But this depends on the social context of communication—as we will argue further below, measuring these dimensions would allow for

For a portrayal sympathetic to groups, we expect two ideal types: *egalitarian but essentializing portrayal* claims to equal access to resources, equal warmth and competence, and a larger proportion of beneficial frames portray the group in a positive light are present, but essentialization, homogenization and differentiation from other groups still occur. This is, on one hand, the typical portrayal of the model minority myth: some groups are portrayed as successful cases of integration primarily to play them against other minority groups, and by ascribing them positive traits as innate features. On the other hand, authors have warned that anti-racist discourses pose the risk of veering also into essentializing egalitarianism by discursively naturalizing differences. A fully *egalitarian portrayal* of groups, *on the other hand* would differ by avoiding these traces of essentialism, homogenization and differentiation.

As can be seen in Figure 1, this spectrum of portrayals also incorporates the intersection between class and race: As both racism research (Fredrickson, 2002, pp. 87-90) and stereotype content theory (Fiske, 2018) argue, access to middle- and upper-class positions have effects on the patterns of stereotypes we would expect: Groups that do not have access to these positions are usually ascribed lower competence and warmth; stereotypes serve to justify their lower status by ascribing them inferiority. Meanwhile, prejudice against groups where members have attained higher status positions within society to a larger degree will take the form of ascribing high competence, but low warmth: Within overtly racist and stereotyping discourses they will be portrayed as competent but malicious to justify their exclusion from the positions they have now attained.

We have argued in the previous section that an inspection of the group-identifying terms would allow to assess the boundaries of group distinction within discourse. Then, the similarities and differences of portrayal along those lines can inform whether discourses follow traditional biological racist lines, culturalist lines, and to what degree culture or race are

tracing how individual messages interact with recipients' attitudes and cognitive biases. Our goal is not to judge individual texts, it is to explain cumulative patterns.

essentialized within a corpus. In languages where these identifiers also incorporate signifiers of gender (for example, we plan on using this framework in German), it can be investigated how the portrayal of groups changes depending on the gender of persons portrayed. For example, the stereotype content model would predict the portrayal of low competence and high warmth for women in cases where pity is expressed (Fiske, 2018).

Overall, we would expect this broad catalogue of dimensions, aggregated over a large corpus, to allow for a comparative mapping of group portrayals (Figure 2a). These patterns could be compared across different corpora to identify differences between different outlets, or between different points in time (Figure 2b). We do not expect the real types of observed patterns to always correspond to the established ideal types—instead, we conceive of real types as situated along a spectrum between those ideal types.

A sufficiently large dataset of expressions of different dimensions could inform an investigation of the effects of individual dimensions and their interaction on different audiences through experimental research, as well as a tracing of structural preconditions for the outcomes on these dimensions: For example, the political orientation of outlets, their demographic composition, existing structural inequalities within a country, the political strength of different groups within a country, or specific key events can affect the portrayal of different groups.

As we have argued in this article, this framework would build on the strengths of large-scale computational content analysis, supplementing existing research with a birds-eye view on larger patterns within public communication. For this greater contribution to be achieved, however, the assumption of the fragmented occurrence of sediments of racism in communicated messages also should yield consequences for media effects research. Individual message elements, such as portrayal of a racialized outgroup as inferior may not be limited to evoking related attitudinal consequences, for instance bolstering perceived outgroup inferiority. Instead, sediments of racism in mediated messages may contribute to a greater picture, that is a cognitive representation of racist ideology. Consequently, media effects research that considers racism as

an overarching driver behind phenomena such as outgroup threat perceptions or stereotyping will have to develop a theory of cumulative media effects (see, (Holbert, 2005)). This should involve an idea of how racism as a schema can be established within individuals' cognitive structures through cumulative exposure to its communicated sediments over time (Wicks, 1992) and how, once it has been internalized, this overarching cognitive pattern may be activated via message priming effects (Domke et al., 1998). We would expect individual mediated messages that refer to only just one or two sub-dimensions of the overall racist ideology to be able to make racism cognitively salient and contribute to it being influential in subsequent behavioral decisions, at least within individuals who have internalized racist thinking (which may be present in the cognitive structures of individuals alongside explicit anti-racist ideologies or convictions).

At the same time, it also means that the absence of such fragments of racist communication or the promotion of anti-racist message elements in public discourse have the power to break the mutually sustaining equilibrium between structural and individual racism. Future media effects research within the realms of racialized group discrimination should put these assumptions to a test—which would allow us to produce further insights into how anti-racist actors could work to alleviate the effects of racial inequality, and to achieve, over time, equality among all groups (Omi & Winant, 2014, pp. 262-266).

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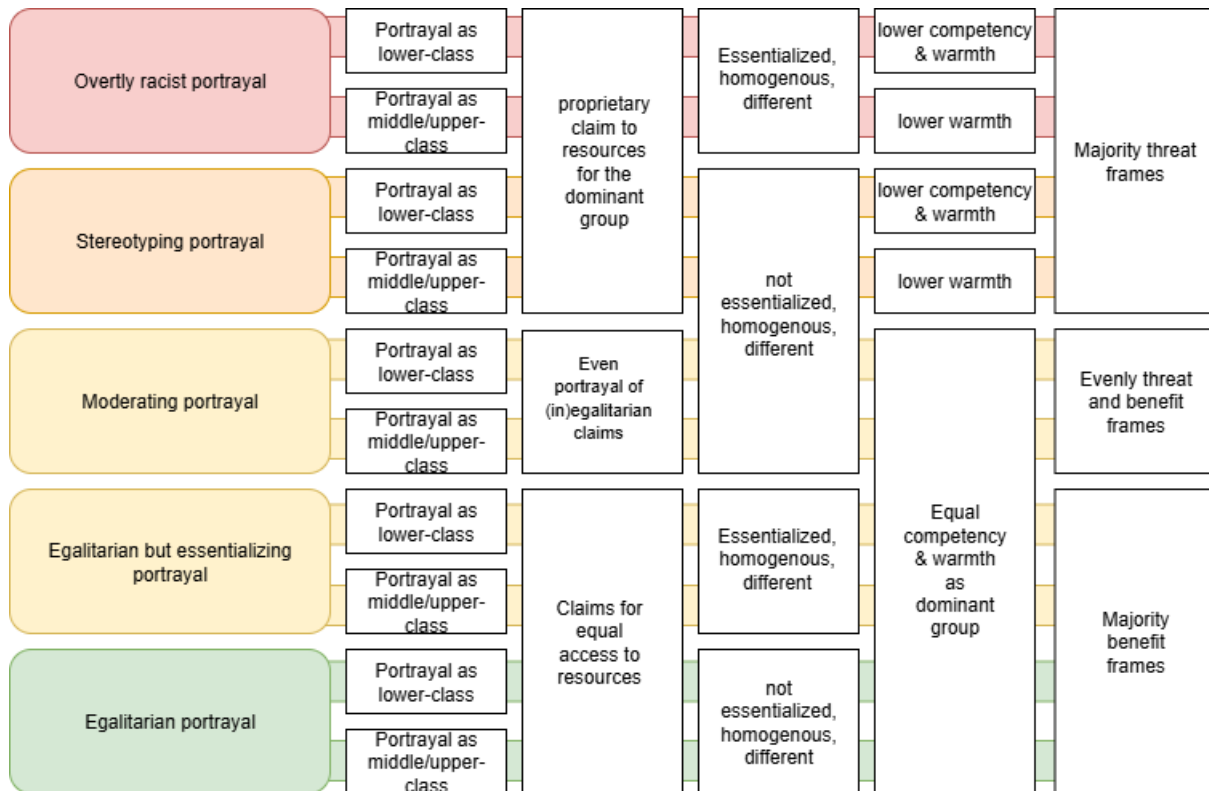


Figure 1: Expected patterns of minority group portrayal within large corpora

Group portrayal can vary not just on the individual dimensions, but in the combination of those dimensions. Essentialized racial resentment is more dangerous not just because it is more negative in degree, but since explicit essentialization means that attributes are understood as unchangeable—making exclusion and submission the only possible courses of action from the view of those internalizing this ideological perspective. Color-coding within the figure indicates these qualitative differences (red indicating the most dangerous pattern, green the most ameliorative).

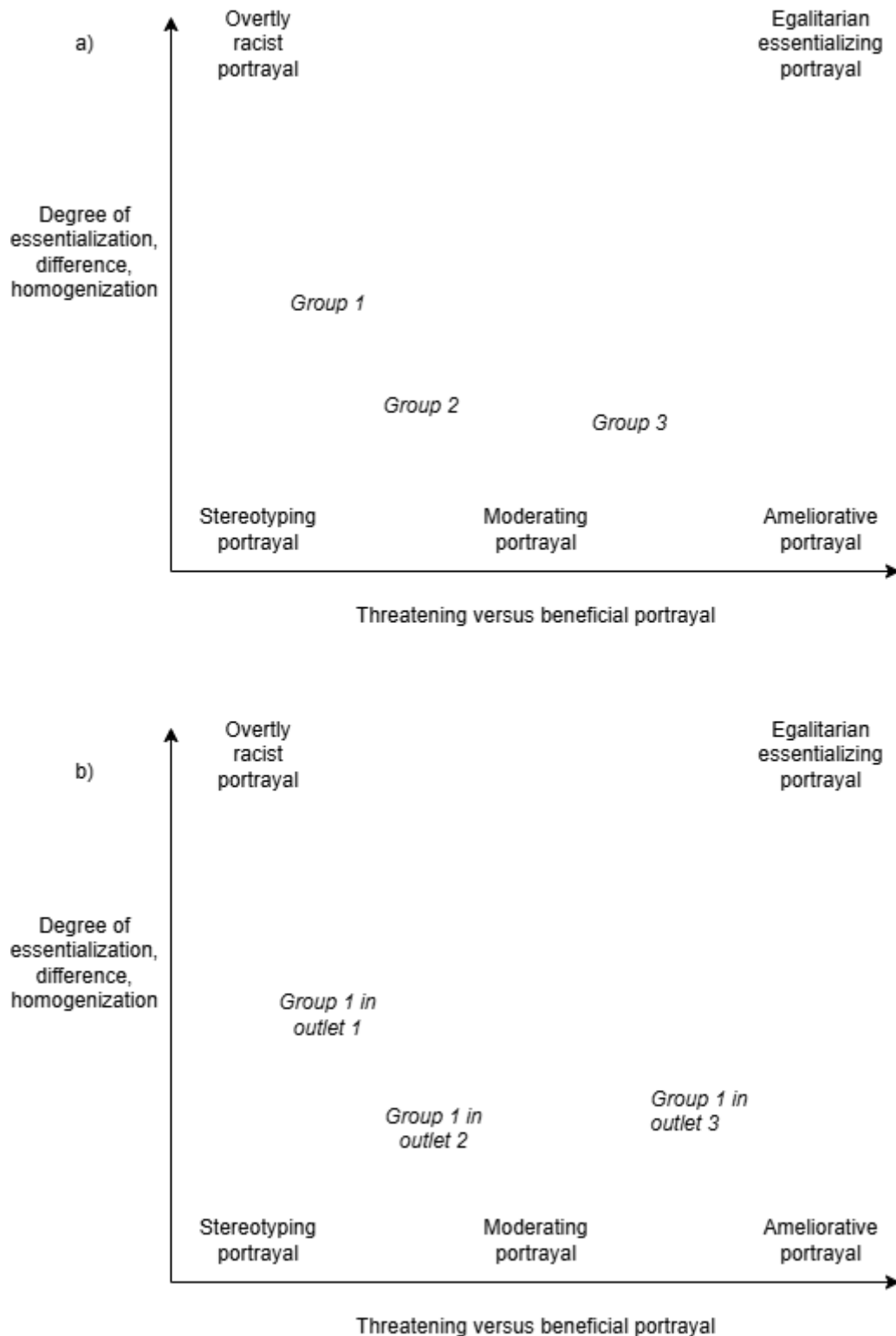


Figure 2: Mapping differential portrayal of racialized groups within large corpora

a) by comparing the portrayal of different groups, we can assess which groups are closer to which ideal typical portrayal—allowing for a relative assessment of their portrayal within reporting

b) by assessing the portrayal of the same group within different corpora, we can compare their tendency towards an alleviating, prejudicial or overtly racist portrayal of groups